At Sravana Belgola, Mackenzie's pandits had been unable to read the mysterious script today known as Brahmi in its local variant: Purvadahalegannad, or Pre-Old Kannada. As a result, they missed the significance of why one of Sravana Belgola's twin hills was named Chandragiri, 'the hill of Chandra'.

That breakthrough was left to Benjamin Lewis Rice, the Bangalore-born son of missionaries who had returned to South India in 1861 to become principal of the Bangalore High School but later joined the Mysore State Civil Service as a school inspector. In 1873 Rice was shown some photographs of rock inscriptions in his area and asked if he could translate them. He had come across apparently similar inscriptions during his tours through Mysore and Coorg and he now became obsessed with finding, copying and deciphering them. The first fruit of his labours was Volume I of *Mysore Inscriptions*, published in 1879, the first systematic survey of South Indian inscriptions. More volumes followed over the years, now collected in the twelve volumes of *Epigraphia Carnatica*, containing facsimiles and translations of some nine thousand inscriptions from the Mysore region.

In 1885, soon after being appointed head of Mysore's Department of Archaeology, Rice and his Kannada-speaking assistants began work on the Sravana Belgola inscriptions. Over the course of four years they located and translated more than eight hundred, the oldest and the most revealing of which were on the walls of a Jain temple known as the Chandragupta Basti, overlooking a cave on the lower slopes of the Chandragiri hill called the Bhadrabahu Gupha. 'Before these inscriptions were deciphered by me,' wrote Rice (not a man to hide his light under a bushel), 'no one had succeeded in reading them, nor was the object with which they were engraved known, so completely had knowledge of